

"It's all your fault," she interrupted. "Again I am poverty stricken and it's all your fault."

Two months later, after the stock market had recovered from its scare and the Dow-Jones averages were back to 485.26, Muffin, or I mean Flicka, flew in from the West Coast, all smiles and chuckles. She brought me an expensive beach bag encrusted with pearls and magenta flowers, and insisted on buying champagne cocktails for the two of us in a small dark highly air-conditioned bar.

It took over an hour and a lot of champagne, but I finally did it. I persuaded her to sell all of her stocks, and to put the money into plain old stodgy government bonds.

Today she seems emotionally stable and well adjusted, has quite a pile of governments, and by way of sublimation owns two temperamental poodles and a finicky Alfa Romeo. I no longer see her proclaiming the glories of a new detergent on television but she has a good steady job modeling Butterfly Frocks or some such name, and often when I open my bill from Bloomingdale's her smiling face and her trim figure will catch my eye as I throw the little brochure of drip-dry dresses into the wastebasket.

MISS ELDERLY SNOWFLAKE

More recently I briefly helped a second-cousin-once-removed with her securities, and she also turned out to be the kind who should stick to the dulllest and most uninteresting bonds possible.

This lady was fresh from a Nevada divorce, was forty-odd and crazy about the boys. She had jet-black hair (due to a rinse), a creamy white skin (due to a layer of make-up), and a penchant for wearing floaty chiffon dresses and high-heeled, very pointed shoes. If she ever kicked anyone it would be worse than being gored by a bull. She had with her a huge alimony settlement, and asked me to help her invest it properly.